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The nomination filing process in an Indian election is a customary show of strength. Candidates rustle up their supporters, hire jeeps and crowds, and move in a cavalcade to the collector's office amidst a shower of garlands and petals. The *mahaul* (climate) of victory has to be created is the underlying assumption. But what happened in Varanasi on 24 April was not just any other roadshow—it was the mightiest ever display of political power during any nomination journey in Indian elections.

The planning for Modi's nomination began almost a week to ten days before D-Day. 'We had a series of meetings and did several trial runs to ensure absolute perfection,' says Nalin Kohli, who was the BJP's media coordinator in Varanasi. High-end platforms were set up at vantage points along the road for the large media contingent to use. A mobile van equipped with cameras and satellite equipment would be placed in front of Modi's open truck so that frontal images of the leader waving to the crowds could be constantly beamed live. All local BJP leaders were told to ensure that their supporters congregated in large numbers. The entire journey was mapped to ensure both maximum crowds and maximum security.

In an effort to give the event an 'inclusive' appeal, the BJP even tried to get Varanasi's Bharat Ratna, shehnai maestro Ustad Bismillah Khan's son, Zamin Hussain Bismillah, as one of the proposers for Modi's nomination. He refused. 'We have been a Congress family for years. Besides, my father's music was always above politics,' he told me later. It was perhaps the only misstep in the BJP's preparations.

Even the chosen date appeared to have been carefully calculated. The 24th of April happened to be the sixth phase of polling, with 117 seats at stake across twelve states and union territories. Central UP, too, was polling that day, apart from the whole of Tamil Nadu, Mumbai and parts of Rajasthan, MP and Bihar. 'We knew that if we created a mega television event, the cameras would focus on Modi and we could capture eyeballs even while the voting was on,' confessed a senior BJP leader to me. The